Image to Video

Turn one still photo into a short moving clip. Upload your image, paste this one motion prompt, and the picture comes to life - water flows, clouds drift and the camera moves, while everything else stays exactly as it was.

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Free student notes - Video & Google Flow set



What this note is: a single shortcut, on its own, so you can save it, print it and use it in seconds. It works in Google Flow, Runway, Kling, Pika, Luma and other image-to-video tools. The full prompt is on page 2.

The copy-and-paste motion prompt

Image to Video Works in: Google Flow - Runway - Kling - Pika - Luma

> Animate this image into a [DURATION, e.g. 5-second] video.
> Keep the subject exactly the same: [SUBJECT - who or what is in the picture, in one line]. Do not change the face, colours, clothes, objects or background.
> Movement - only this moves: [ACTION - one or two gentle movements, e.g. water flows, leaves sway, she smiles and waves once].
> Camera: [CAMERA MOVE - e.g. slow push-in / gentle pan left to right / still camera].
> Mood and light: [MOOD - e.g. calm morning light, warm and peaceful]. Style: realistic, smooth, natural motion.
> Do NOT: morph or melt anything, change the face, add new people or objects, add text or logos, warp hands, or use fast jerky movement.

Fill the brackets: keep every line, and replace only the parts in [brackets]. Short, clear lines work better than one long paragraph.

What each line does

Line	What it controls
Subject	Locks who or what must stay the same, so the tool does not invent a different person, animal or place.
Action	Names the only movement allowed. One or two gentle movements stay clean; five movements at once usually break.
Camera	Tells the shot how to move - push-in, pan or still - so the framing does not wander on its own.
Mood and light	Sets the feeling of the clip and stops the light changing halfway through.
Duration	Short clips (about 5 seconds) stay sharper and make fewer mistakes than long ones.
Do NOT line	The negative prompt. It blocks morphing faces, melting objects, extra fingers and unwanted text - the most common faults.

Steps in Google Flow - step by step

1. **Create a project** in Google Flow and choose the image-to-video option (Frames to Video).
2. **Upload your photo** as the ingredient / first frame. Use a clear, sharp photo - a blurry photo animates badly.
3. **Paste the prompt** from page 2, with your brackets filled in.
4. **Set duration and ratio:** about 5 seconds to start; 16:9 for YouTube, 9:16 for Reels, Shorts and TikTok.
5. **Generate, then pick the cleanest take.** Check faces, hands and edges before you download.
6. **Bad take? Change ONE thing only** - usually make the action smaller - and generate again. Changing everything at once tells you nothing.

> **Same steps in other tools:** Runway, Kling, Pika and Luma all work the same way - upload the image first, paste the same prompt, set the duration, then generate. Learn the prompt once and you can use it everywhere; only the buttons change.

Before you press generate - a 30-second check

- Is the photo sharp, bright and not cut off at the edges?
- Does the action line name only one or two gentle movements?
- Is the Do NOT line still there? Never delete it to save space.
- Is the ratio right for where the video will be posted?

Fixing the three most common faults

Fault	Fix
Face changes or melts	Make the action smaller, keep the camera still, and add "do not change the face" to the prompt.
Everything moves at once	Your action line asked for too much. Keep one movement and delete the rest.
Strange extra objects appear	Strengthen the Do NOT line: "add no new people, objects or text."

Worked example - a mountain valley photo

For a green valley photo with a river and snow peaks, the prompt filled in:

> Animate this image into a 5-second video. Keep the subject exactly the same: a mountain valley with a river and snow peaks behind - do not change the colours, hills, river path or sky.
> Movement - only this moves: the river water flows gently towards the camera, and thin clouds drift slowly across the peaks.
> Camera: very slow push-in. Mood and light: calm, fresh morning light. Style: realistic, smooth, natural motion.
> Do NOT: morph the mountains, add buildings or people, add text or logos, or use fast jerky movement.

Why it works: only two things move - water and clouds - and both move in real life, so the clip looks natural.

Three quick add-ons

Your photo	Change these lines
Portrait	Action: "She smiles gently, blinks naturally and nods once." Camera: still. Add: "do not change the face, eyes or smile shape."
Science diagram	Action: "Arrows glow one by one in order, water flows through the pipe." Camera: still. Add: "keep every label sharp and readable - do not bend or rewrite any word."
Product photo	Action: "Light sweeps slowly across the product; it turns a quarter turn only." Camera: slow push-in. Add: "keep shape, colour, logo and packaging text exactly the same."

> **Golden rule:** if a person is standing still in the photo, ask for a wave, a smile or a turn of the head - not running or a full scene change. Small movement, clean video.

Use your own pictures. Animate photos you took yourself or free images you are allowed to use. Do not present someone else's work as your own.

Real people need permission. Never animate a photo of a real person to make them say or do something they did not do - that is a fake video of a real person, even as a joke.

Label it honestly. When you post an AI-animated clip, say it was made with AI from a still photo.